

Book Title: **Eternal Wisdom, Emerging Worlds**

(Sikh Thought on Faith, Freedom, Identity, and Artificial Intelligence)

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Reviewer: **Hardev Singh Virk**, Professor of Eminence, SGGS World University, Fatehgarh Sahib (Punjab)

Prof. Pashaura Singh in his Foreword has given a brief introduction about both the authors. I believe he has read only the Preface and then summed up his views about the book. My interaction with authors goes back to Guru Nanak Dev University (GNDU), Amritsar, where Dr DP Singh joined as a Research Scholar and Faculty Member in 1983, and Dr Bhai Harbans Lal was a frequent visitor to participate in Conferences held in GNDU. Most of these articles included in this book have been published by the authors; by Dr Lal as his Blogs, and Dr Singh in various magazines and journals. This book has been written with a futuristic outlook and a purpose to create awareness among its readers to remain watchful while using AI based technologies.

Authors write in the Preface: “In November 2022, the release of ChatGPT marked a watershed moment in human history. Within months, artificial intelligence (AI) shifted from a specialized technical domain to a force reshaping education, creativity, governance, and spiritual practice. By 2024, AI systems were writing poetry, diagnosing diseases, generating deepfake avatars of the deceased, and making decisions that affected millions of lives”. Further, the purpose of writing this book is explained by the authors as follows: “This book addresses multiple audiences, each with distinct needs. For academic scholars in religious studies, philosophy, and science and technology studies, we offer a substantive non-Western voice in debates dominated by Judeo-Christian and secular frameworks. For AI researchers and technologists grappling with ethical questions, we provide a comprehensive moral vocabulary grounded in concepts like divine order, service, and collective flourishing. For Sikh practitioners and community leaders, we demonstrate how traditional teachings remain dynamically relevant without requiring dilution or distortion. For general readers concerned

about technology's impact on human dignity and spiritual life, we offer accessible yet rigorous analysis. For policymakers navigating questions of AI governance, religious freedom, and pluralism, we illustrate how wisdom traditions can inform public discourse without imposing sectarian agendas.”

The book has 20 Chapters divided into two parts. Bhai H. Lal, in the opening Chapter of this book, explains the need for making Sri Guru Granth Sahib available in all languages as its universal message transcends geography, ethnicity, and culture. He is highly critical of our approach to Sikhi: “We Sikhs take great pride in the universality of the Gurus' message, meaning that our Gurus revealed it for the benefit of all peoples and communities. Our clerics and our leaders miss no opportunity to emphasize this distinction of our Guru’s message. Similarly, we speak of our Gurdwaras and other congregational institutions open to everyone in the global village. But we fail to realize that by trussing Sikh beliefs and practices far too tightly with Punjabi language, ethnicity, and lifestyle, we commit the sin of utterly refusing to share our religion with the rest of the world”.

In the 2nd Chapter, DP Singh sums up the creation process of Guru Nanak in SGGS as follows: “Guru Nanak's reflections on creation present one of the most comprehensive spiritual visions of the cosmos found in world religious literature. His hymns neither attempt to provide a scientific textbook nor discourage rational investigation; instead, they inspire humility, wonder, and a lifelong search for truth. The comparisons presented in this article indicate that several themes articulated by Guru Nanak, including the unknowability of the precise moment of creation, the emergence of the universe through Divine command, the immensity of creation, the possibility of multiple worlds, the origin and diversity of life, and the eventual transformation of the cosmos, display remarkable conceptual resonance with contemporary scientific understanding. At the same time, Guru Nanak consistently reminds humanity that ultimate reality transcends complete intellectual comprehension”.

In the 3rd Chapter, both the authors join hands to explain the martyrdom of Guru Tegh Bahadur for freedom of conscience and religious pluralism in societies: “This article explores Guru Tegh Bahadur’s martyrdom through the lens of pluralistic societies. It draws connections between his advocacy for universal religious freedom and contemporary frameworks of interfaith harmony, human rights, and secular governance”. In 4th Chapter, Bhai Lal explains the significance of Langar as practical expression of Sikh faith translated into action. He goes on to describe the Langar Sewa of various Sikh organizations globally.

Langar is explained beautifully as follows: “Langar emerges as an act of justice, compassion, and shared humanity, demonstrating how spiritual principles can be lived rather than just proclaimed”.

In Chapter 5, DP Singh has given a vivid description of legacy of Guru Gobind Singh: “His advocacy for the equality of all people, regardless of caste, gender, or religion, underscores the relevance of inclusivity and social justice. His leadership style, rooted in humility and empowerment, offers valuable lessons for modern leaders. Through the teachings of Guru Gobind Singh, individuals are encouraged to lead lives of integrity, compassion, and unity, making his legacy a timeless source of inspiration for the world today”. In Chapter 6, DP and Lal give the historical analysis of revelation of the Khalsa by Guru Gobind Singh: *“Understanding this distinction between "revealing" versus "creating" the Khalsa provides several important insights. First, it establishes historical continuity in the development of Sikh institutions from Guru Nanak through Guru Gobind Singh. Second, it helps explain why not all Sikhs immediately adopted Amrit after 1699, even as they still considered themselves part of the Khalsa Panth. Finally, it demonstrates how Guru Gobind Singh's actions represented both practical organizational reform and profound theological innovation”*.

In Chapter 7, both the authors focus on “Vaisakhi in Sikh Tradition” and trace its scriptural roots and historical transformations. They conclude: " By tracing Vaisakhi’s layered development, this article demonstrates that its enduring relevance lies in its capacity to integrate spiritual realization with social transformation. Vaisakhi stands not merely as a historical anniversary, but as a continuing call to embody Sikh ideals of equality, courage, humility, and divine awareness in collective life”. In Chapter 8, authors discuss “Anand Marriage Act” and its historical origins and implications. In Chapter 9, they describe the limitations of Sikhi due to its entanglement with Punjabi nationalism and ethnicity: “By distinguishing religion from ethnicity, embracing intercultural pedagogies, and supporting diverse Sikh identities, the global Sikh community can make Sikhi accessible to seekers worldwide, without compromising its spiritual integrity. When Sikhi is disentangled from Punjabi nationalism, its core message of divine unity, justice, equality, and compassion becomes universally compelling”. Chapter 10 continues to discuss the same theme as presented in Chapter 9. The authors provide a framework to improve the situation: *“Examining historical, linguistic, institutional, and sociological factors, the article highlights the need to reclaim Guru Nanak’s intercultural approach through multilingual education, inclusive gurdwara practices, global translations, and broader representation. By*

distinguishing Sikh spiritual principles from ethnic expressions, Sikhi can evolve as a truly global faith while preserving its authentic identity and universal humanistic foundations”.

In Chapter 11, DP Singh tries to explore the environmental wisdom in the Sikh Scripture (SGGS). It is a new approach to the study of SGGS. He traces a profound reverence for nature expressed in the SGGS. According to DP: “Key verses, such as “*Pavan Guru, Pani Pita, Mata Dharat Mahat,*” highlight the Earth, air, and water as revered life-givers and spiritual guides. SGGS condemns greed and material exploitation while promoting virtues such as contentment, humility, and selfless service (seva), all of which foster ecological balance and sustainability”. In Chapter 12, Bhai Lal uses a metaphor of breaking the egg shell, first used by Max Arthur Macauliffe, the celebrated translator of SGGS, to examine the contemporary condition of Sikh community. He calls for a return to Guru Nanak’s rational, ethical, and spiritually authentic vision, urging Sikhs to embrace self-reflection, scriptural understanding, and reform to preserve the vitality and universality of the Sikh faith.

In Chapter 13, DP finds fault in modern practices vs Guru Nanak’s vision which emphasized the oneness of God, equality, social justice, selfless service (seva), truth, and living a balanced life. He is of the opinion that the rise of materialism, caste discrimination, religious ritualism, sectarianism, and the neglect of seva are the main causes of this divergence. In Chapter 14, authors use Sikh Philosophy to explore the phenomena of super-aging and mental resilience. On the basis of integrative model of aging, authors conclude: “Cognitive longevity may not depend solely on genetics or lifestyle but is shaped by a harmonious interplay among body, mind, and spirit, as emphasized in Sikh philosophy”. In Chapter 15, DP Singh traces the multifaceted legacy of Harmandir Sahib and concludes: “*Harmandir Sahib’s legacy transcends religion, offering a timeless model of compassion and unity that reinforces its role as a spiritual and cultural beacon for humanity in an increasingly divided world”.*

In the Preface, authors give the classification of Chapters as follows: “The first section of fifteen chapters establishes the philosophical foundations to examine core Sikh teachings on universal spirituality, religious freedom, ecological consciousness, social equality, and institutional reform. The second section of five Chapters then applies these philosophical resources to the specific challenge of AI”. Keeping this classification in view, Chapters 16-20 gain prominence in this book. In Chapter 16, authors conclude on the Sikh perspective of GPT-5 as follows: “From a Sikh perspective, GPT-5 is neither inherently liberating nor inherently perilous. Like all tools, its impact is determined by the consciousness with which

humanity wields it. When guided by greed, ego, and disregard for nature, it risks becoming an extension of Maya and exploitation. Conversely, when used with humility, justice, and a spirit of seva (selfless service), it can become a potent instrument for upliftment. Sikhism does not reject technological progress; instead, it calls for grounding innovation in spiritual wisdom (*Gian*), righteous action (*Kirat*), and selfless service (*Seva*)”.

In Chapter 17, DP Singh provides a Sikh critique of Artificial Intelligence in tune with teachings of SGGS: “Rather than rejecting innovation, Sikhism calls for spiritually guided technology that upholds human dignity, service, and divine remembrance. The machine must serve humanity, not replace its soul”. Chapter 18 “Deepfake Eternity vs. Eternal Naam: Sikh Responses to Artificial Intelligence” is one of the most significant Chapters of this volume. The authors are highly critical of new technology versus eternal Naam. They conclude: “In choosing the path of *Naam* over digital simulation, Sikhs affirm that authentic eternity cannot be programmed, purchased, or artificially preserved; it can only be realized through the timeless practice of divine remembrance that connects all beings across the apparent boundaries of life and death”. In Chapter 19, DP Singh pleads for use of AI technology to enhance knowledge and understanding of Sikh doctrines by improving access to information, enabling personalized learning, supporting language translation, and facilitating the analysis of Sikh scriptures. Author recommends the use of AI through digital libraries, intelligent assistants, immersive virtual experiences, and collaborative platforms to deepen engagement with Sikh teachings and cultural heritage. In Chapter 20, DP Singh recommends to harness AI to promote Sikhism. I agree with the views of author: “Artificial Intelligence presents unprecedented opportunities to promote Sikhism by expanding access to authentic knowledge, preserving cultural heritage, and connecting the global Sikh community through innovative digital technologies. AI-powered tools can democratize learning, overcome linguistic and geographical barriers, facilitate scholarly research, and create engaging educational experiences that inspire both current and future generations”.

I consider this book as a welcome addition to Sikh literature. Authors have joined hands to provide the readers a futuristic view of Sikhi based on AI technology and its impact on Sikh society, in particular, and the global society, in general. Authors have given Bibliography after each Chapter but I feel lack of Index at the end of this book. I feel privileged to review this book for the intelligent reader and researcher of Sikhi, its legacy, and its institutions.